or at least recognizable demonstrations of this adherence – would have been increasingly evident to the ascendant Shansabanis. Although their pre-imperial forebears had doubtless participated in the mercantile networks within Afghanistan, the truly transregional connections needed for long-term commercial sustainability appear to have been plied largely by the region's Jewish communities, such as the one of Jam-Firuzkuh.[83] But in Afghanistan during the eleventh–twelfth centuries, empire-building – essentially another mode of benefiting from commerce, with the added advantage of being able to structure and direct it – lay in the hands of confessionally Muslim elites such as the Saljuqs and Ghaznavids. In order to become fitting competitors in an already crowded field of imperial contenders, and to fill the vacuum left by the declining Saljuq and Ghaznavid powers, appropriation and deployment of these fading predecessors' legibly *Islamic* – with a strong Persianate twist – imperial presences afforded the best outlet for the Shansabanis' own burgeoning political and economic momentum.

The adoption of Islam, however, was not sufficient for effective *kingship*, particularly in light of the extremely variegated nature of *both* by the beginning of the second millennium CE. Precisely because the Shansabanis' transformation from autonomous or nominally ruled nomads and/or practitioners of seasonal transhumance into expansionist rulers is not fully retrievable from the surviving textual and/or material sources, another look at the story related by Juzjani can provide at least the bases for further insights.

Aside from Amir Banji, the other protagonist of Juzjani's anecdote was the cosmopolitan Jewish merchant from Ghur, who surely served as narrative short-hand for the appreciable Jewish community of Jam-Firuzkuh. As noted above, Jews were settled in the area from at least the early eleventh century and remained possibly through the last quarter of the twelfth century,[84] based on the dates in the Judeo-Persian inscribed tombstones rediscovered at Kushkak, outside Jam. Taking into account the activities of the other important Jewish settlements in Afghanistan, it seems that the one at Jam-Firuzkuh would also have been prompted by mercantilism.[85]

But again, the location of Jam-Firuzkuh was less than propitious for commerce: although the site lay at the confluence of the Jam Rud and the Hari Rud, the rivers were volatile and seasonally difficult to cross.[86] Moreover, the site was within a mountain fastness not easily accessed from the well-plied routes connecting Herat, Balkh,[87] and beyond toward the northeast. Nevertheless, Jam-Firuzkuh's Judeo-Persian funerary inscriptions noted a variety of professions among the deceased, such as goldsmith and banker. This variety in turn would indicate that the area might have been equipped with at least some of the auxiliary "industries" and labor specialties of banking and manufacture necessary for the full development and exploitation of a mercantile economy. In the end, then, Juzjani's